

Decades of university research confirms that my parents were practising the number one habit for raising successful kids:

Regular family dinners.

A comprehensive 16-year-long study by Michigan State University found that the simple act of having regular family dinners was the single biggest predictor of academic achievement.

More than that, the study found that a shared family mealtime was more influential than studying, attending religious services or playing sports.

Too general for you?

The study found that kids who chowed down with their parents were:

- twice as likely to get As at school (yes, mealtimes were more important for this than a fancy private school)
- less likely to take drugs or have a teenage pregnancy
- more resilient, less prone to bullying and less likely to suffer mental health problems as they got older, and more likely to have better self-esteem.

Pretty cool, huh?

Remember the motto of this book:

‘As parents it’s okay if we get most things wrong . . . as long as we get a few *big* things right.’

Well, having family dinners is one of those ‘big things’ that my parents got right.

So let’s you and I talk about how you can recreate that experience for *your* family . . . taking a little inspiration from the Japanese.

The honourable mealtime

I heard about this from my mate Matt, who was best man at our wedding.